Marketing without financial runway

Prepared for Casey Shore, Lemonade and CineGen · 8 September 2026

The decision

Build an operator that makes the founder's next useful action easier: discover real questions, inspect the product, prepare helpful responses and demonstrations, keep the evidence, and turn repeated friction into small engineering requests. Begin at zero cash. Early acquisition often depends on direct recruitment and unusually attentive onboarding; automating preparation does not remove the need to learn from customers. This is experienced founder guidance, not a promise of growth. Paul Graham, Do Things that Don't Scale, July 2013

Bullseye is a learning loop: consider all 19 channels, select a few inexpensive tests, evaluate acquisition cost, customer volume and customer fit, and focus on the best measured opportunity. The supplied Traction excerpt supports this reading (book pages 19–26). Its emphasis on cheap tests is compatible with zero-cash work; it does not prescribe a universal order of channels or a reinvestment percentage. Gabriel Weinberg interview

The first experiments

The following are starting hypotheses, not proven winners. Keep at most three shortlisted at once, define the audience and success threshold before starting, and record actual observations instead of interpreting silence as a sale.

Product	Initial zero-cash test	Evidence to collect	Engineering implication
Lemonade	A real walkthrough answering a specific private-document question	Voluntary feedback, installation friction and qualifying purchases	A reproducible demo and privacy-preserving checkout attribution
Lemonade	A small onboarding clinic for people already asking about local AI	Where setup succeeds or stops, with permission	Fix the repeated activation blocker before broad promotion
Lemonade	One practical tutorial addressing observed confusion	Relevant reader questions and attributed purchases	Improve only the product/docs gaps that the tutorial exposes
CineGen	A real storyboard-to-export walkthrough using a narrow creative task	First successful export and creator feedback	Audit export/onboarding friction before acquiring more users
CineGen	A reusable project/tutorial for a specific creator audience	Whether creators finish the intended task	Make a repeatable template only after validating the task
CineGen	A small creator onboarding session	Buyer needs versus feature suggestions	Turn repeated, evidenced friction into acceptance criteria

These tests adapt direct observation and founder-led recruitment. Distinguish the customer's problem, need and proposed solution; a requested feature is not itself proof of a market. YC: User Observation, August 2016

The current Lemonade site describes a Windows/Linux local assistant, a $49 perpetual license and a 14-day trial, with no behavioral telemetry. Use voluntary source answers and checkout records rather than silently introducing product analytics. These are current vendor claims, not independently benchmarked capabilities. Lemonade product site

CineGen now presents a browser production workspace covering storyboard, characters, generation, timeline editing and review. Its 3D scene creator is marked beta. The free offer includes one project and watermarked 720p exports; its paid plans differ in included generation allowances. Recheck live entitlements and costs before publishing a price or promising a demo. CineGen product site

A cash rule the model cannot rewrite

Pending receipts differ from available funds. Settlement, fees, refunds, disputes and reserves matter; gross sales and subscription list prices do not establish money available for marketing. Stripe: Balances and settlement time

Signal therefore records owner-confirmed settled surplus after fees, refunds, delivery costs and obligations. Unknown deductions mean no confirmed surplus. Avoid deducting a cost twice if it is already included in the supplied net figure. The deterministic envelope is:

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max(0, min(owner cap, reinvestment share × max(0, settled surplus − additional reserve)) − marketing spend − commitments)
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The initial policy allocates 10% of recorded surplus with a $25 total cap. These are conservative editable operating assumptions, not research-established optima. The envelope begins at $0 and does not refill because a month passes. Product ledgers remain separate; refunds and corrections immediately reduce eligibility.

Tier	Evidence gate	Eligible work
Bootstrap	No completed promising test	Zero-cash discovery, drafts, demos and onboarding
Organic	A completed test meets predefined customer/fit/CAC criteria	Continue organic work and learning
Funded tests	Promising test plus recorded surplus and available envelope	Reserve a concrete, affordable experiment
Repeatable	Two promising completed tests in the same channel plus available funds	Consider bounded expansion; keep measuring contribution

Cash tiers and the Bullseye core channel are separate. A model's confidence cannot promote either. Existing experiment revenue is measurement evidence, not an automatic cash-ledger deposit. These gates do not prove statistical causality.

Useful responses instead of promotional volume

Answer the actual question, retrieve relevant product facts, disclose affiliation naturally, and avoid invented customer experience. Store approved voice preferences and examples. Natural language is a writing goal, not an instruction to pretend an autonomous system is a human employee.

Reddit's current spam policy explicitly includes continuous promotional bots and repetitive unsolicited engagement. A useful operator prepares specific responses, respects community rules and suppression, and does not turn a writing model into a mass-posting loop. Reddit Spam policy, updated May 2026

For search content, originality and usefulness matter. AI can assist research and structure, while large volumes of low-value generated pages may violate scaled content policies. Google Search guidance, December 2025

Affiliate endorsements need clear material-connection disclosures, and testimonials cannot invent experience. Commercial email has identity and opt-out requirements; the US rule alone does not establish permission for every jurisdiction or provider. FTC endorsement guidance FTC CAN-SPAM guide

UTM tags identify campaign referrals. Keep source, medium, campaign and creative identifiers consistent, but do not confuse a tagged visit with a paying customer or proof that the campaign caused the purchase. Google Analytics campaign URL guidance

Memory, tools and the engineering feedback loop

The likely Obelisk reference uses a local SQLite evidence index shared by a CLI and desktop app. Its durable memories retain access to original evidence. Signal adapts those ideas rather than claiming to install Obelisk itself. Obelisk project

Temporal graph designs retain provenance and invalidate outdated relationships when new evidence contradicts them. Signal uses product-scoped memory nodes, relationships, source references, observation timestamps, confidence and explicit supersession. Model-written ideas remain hypotheses; owner corrections and actual page observations have distinct origins. Retrieval combines bounded lexical ranking and graph neighbors. A local graph is an engineering choice, not evidence that memory storage itself produces revenue. Graphiti episodes Graphiti temporal architecture

Each engineering request should include the product, problem, source evidence, channel/test, smallest manual workaround, expected metric, priority and testable acceptance criteria. An affiliate pilot should first establish partner interest, referral-through-checkout attribution, duplicate/self-referral handling, refund reversal and a commission ledger. A complete affiliate platform is a later proposal, not a prerequisite for finding the first interested partner.

ComfyUI exposes workflow submission, queue/history inspection and saved-output retrieval. Persist its prompt ID: successful submission means queued, not rendered. Use installed local workflow nodes and models; inspect capabilities before offering generation. Keep generated creative distinct from actual product screenshots. Do not globally interrupt another application's render when cancelling one job. ComfyUI server API Official workflow example

Remote product pages belong in an isolated browser without Node integration or Signal's privileged preload. Keep authentication outside prompts and memory. Product screenshots and page text are observations; a landing-page claim alone does not verify an authenticated workflow. Electron security guidance

Limits and the next evidence

No reviewed source establishes a universal CAC target, optimal reinvestment share, or guaranteed winning channel for either product. SEO and community work consume time even when their cash cost is zero. CineGen's generation costs and Lemonade's one-time licensing economics require different net-contribution records.

This research stops because the consequential decisions have primary support or an explicit limitation. More generic marketing searches are unlikely to decide the next step. Actual customer conversations, product use, local runtime tests and recorded experiment outcomes will. Integration availability and implementation validation are reported separately from this research.

Sources were accessed 8 September 2026. The Traction PDF was consulted locally; its text and external account credentials are not embedded in Signal.